construction, multi-modal transport initiatives, railway modernization, inland waterways, coastal shipping, and port development underlines its seriousness. In fact, better logistics has become the dominant theme of India's neighbourhood outreach.

India's experience westwards is less positive for reasons that the world knows well. Nevertheless, the Chabahar port project with Iran and the sea access it can provide for Afghanistan represent important openings. Iran's considerable potential as a transit corridor to Eurasia is worth exploring. So too is the larger International North-South Transport Corridor that can facilitate transportation to Russia and Europe, as well as the Ashgabat Agreement that connects the Indian Ocean to Central Asia. Developments in the Gulf and West Asia may provide still more options in the days ahead.

An Indian Ocean strategy naturally means paying more attention to its maritime neighbours. As is common in such cases, history and sociology are mixed blessings. Relationship-building is expressed in terms of political visibility, greater cooperation and more projects with Sri Lanka, Maldives, Mauritius and Seychelles. An integrated view is emerging of trade, tourism, infrastructure, environment, blue economy and security. India has also been partnering these countries in capability building by providing radars, coastal surveillance equipment, vessels and aircraft and by establishing maritime infrastructure. The cooperation agenda today covers white shipping, blue economy, disaster response, anti-piracy and counterterrorism, as well as hydrography. It was reassuring for these nations to see how staunchly India stood by them during the corona pandemic.

The importance of these maritime relationships to India's security interests cannot be overstated. After all, this is the core from which India could help build a larger pan-Indian Ocean architecture. It is therefore critical to ensure that this proximate zone remain sensitive to India's interests. It is also desirable that the Indian Ocean does not become an arena for intense competition. Island states will have their own sensitivities but also their calculations. While they may seek to make the best of their chances, the combination of political comfort, economic collaboration and cultural affinities will play its part. Responsibility for peace, prosperity, security and stability rests primarily on the approach of resident powers. Their collective